Order of Operations (BIDMAS/BODMAS)

Exam code: 0607

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Order of operations (BIDMAS/BODMAS)

What is the order of operations (BODMAS/BIDMAS)?

- If there is more than one **operation** in a calculation then they should be done in the following order
  - **Brackets**: ( )
    - Perform any calculation(s) **inside** brackets first
  - **Powers** or **Indices** (sometimes **O**rder): ^{2}, ^{3}, √ and similar
    - These include **powers, roots, reciprocals**
  - **Divisions** or **Multiplications**: × or ÷
    - If there are more than one of these then work them out left to right
    - Division includes **fractions**
  - **Additions** or **Subtractions**: + or -
    - If there are more than one of these then work them out left to right
- The acronym **BODMAS** or **BIDMAS** can help you remember the order of operations

In what order should fractions and roots be dealt with?

- **Fractions** mean **division** in calculations (BO**D**MAS/BI**D**MAS)
- There may be "invisible brackets" around the numerator and around the denominator
  - e.g. $\frac{2+5}{7-2}$ means $(2+5) \div (7-2)$
  - Instead of brackets we extend the fraction line to show exactly what is on the top and what is on the bottom
- **Roots** are powers (B**O**DMAS/BI**D**MAS)
- There may be "invisible brackets" under the root
  - e.g. $\sqrt{9+16}$ means $\sqrt{(9+16)}$

Stuck on something?
Ask questions and get help with exactly what you're revising.
Got it
Help me understand

How do I use a calculator for BIDMAS/BODMAS questions?

- Ensure that you enter a long or complicated calculation carefully
  - For most modern calculators, the calculation can be typed in exactly as it is written on paper
  - You may need to use additional brackets on older calculators

Examiner Tips and Tricks

Make sure that you always check that your answer seems sensible!

Worked Example

Work out $(5 - 3) + 2 \times 7^2$.

Answer:

Use **BODMAS**

First calculate anything inside brackets, $5 - 3 = 2$, so the question becomes

$$2 + 2 \times 7^2$$

Then any powers, $7^2 = 49$

$$2 + 2 \times 49$$

followed by any divisions and multiplications, $2 \times 49 = 98$

$$2 + 98$$

and finally any additions and subtractions, $2 + 98 = 100$

$$(5 - 3) + 2 \times 7^2 = 100$$

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